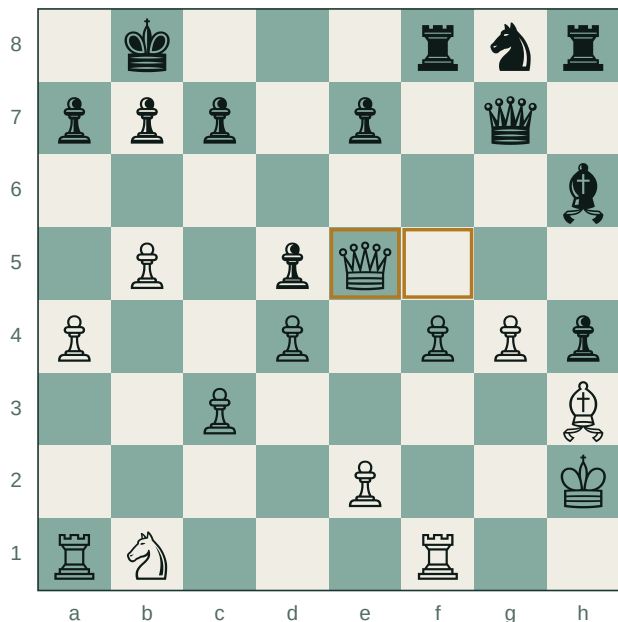


Capture the defender: Black, move 22

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 22.Qe5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

22...Bxf4+ 23. Rxf4 Qxe5 24. dxe5 Rxf4

22...Bxf4+ Check restricts White to 5 legal replies here. From f4 it attacks king on h2 and queen on e5. Recorded reply: **23.Rxf4**.

23...Qxe5 The queen captures the queen on e5. Recorded reply: **24.dxe5**.

24...Rxf4 The rook captures the rook on f4.

At the end, nominal material is White 17 / Black 19 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on h2. Geometrically undefended: rook on a1. Check for tactical protection.